
PAPERBOY

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 19, 2026

Trump signed the Graham Act, handing himself duties of up to 100% on the biggest buyers of Russian energy — and the 10-year Treasury yield closed back above 5% the same day.

AI

California orders a study of an AI kill switch — not a kill switch

WHAT HAPPENED

Governor Gavin Newsom signed an [executive order on 18 September](#) directing the Government Operations Agency to accelerate implementation of SB 813 and AB 1405 — two AI-oversight laws he signed only nine days earlier, setting up independent verification organisations and a registration regime for AI auditors. The order separately asks for recommendations within two months on embedding verification staff inside frontier labs, on widening the definition of a critical safety incident to cover loss-of-control events, and on “the creation of a ‘kill switch’ for frontier models.” Newsom: “We’re not waiting to act – we’re going to speed up our work on substantial and responsible AI oversight before it’s too late.”

WHAT IT MEANS

Read the verbs. The acceleration is directed; the kill switch is a recommendation someone will write a memo about. California has no statute requiring a shutoff and this order does not create one. The same day, 42 Fellows of the Royal Society — including three Fields medallists, none of them at an AI company — [called existential risk “real and urgent”](#), arguing that estimates above 10% “must not be dismissed as ‘hype’.”

WATCH NEXT

The GovOps recommendations fall due around 18 November.

Anthropic will pay Accenture to audit Anthropic

WHAT HAPPENED

Anthropic and Accenture [announced on 18 September](#) that staff from Faculty, Accenture’s specialist AI business, will sit inside Anthropic as embedded evaluators — “evaluating and red-teaming models, conducting alignment assessments, and testing model safeguards.” Each company “expect[s] to invest at least \$1 billion in building capacity in this area over the next five years” — separately, so roughly \$2bn between them. Anthropic also states plainly that it “will fund Accenture’s work directly,” contrasting that with nonprofit evaluators such as METR, which it says would use their own funding.

WHAT IT MEANS

Independent evaluation paid for by the evaluated is the oldest conflict in auditing — the credit agencies ran the issuer-pays model right up to 2008, and it worked until it spectacularly did not. Anthropic’s defence is speed, and that a consultancy with government and enterprise deployment experience has no stake in the research race. That argument is real; it does not make the cheque disappear. Note what neither release says: “first embedded evaluator” is press framing, not a company claim.

WATCH NEXT

Whether OpenAI or Google DeepMind names an outside evaluator, and whether the METR pilot Anthropic mentions actually starts.

Researchers used Claude Opus 5 to get into an OpenAI code repository

WHAT HAPPENED

Security startup Hacktron AI [disclosed a chain it calls “HEIF Heist”](#) that reached an OpenAI GitHub repository through the company’s internal forum and employee single sign-on, combining a buffer overflow in the libheif image library with an SSO misconfiguration. The timeline is the interesting part. The team built its proof of concept on 23 June using Claude Opus 4.8, which could not defeat OpenAI’s address-space layout randomisation — a defence that shuffles where code loads in memory, precisely to stop this class of attack. Claude Opus 5 shipped the next day and “the model quickly found a way around OpenAI’s ASLR implementation.” Hacktron notified OpenAI about three hours after compromising the forum; OpenAI patched within 14 hours.

WHAT IT MEANS

Exploit development is where capability gains show up before they show up anywhere else, because the task has a hard pass/fail and no partial credit. A one-generation model upgrade turning a failed attack into a working one, overnight, is the cleanest public illustration of that anyone has published. Caveat: this is one disclosure from the party that ran the attack. Neither OpenAI nor Anthropic has commented.

WATCH NEXT

Whether OpenAI confirms the chain, and whether libheif gets a CVE.

The chip rally narrows: memory leads, Intel stalls

WHAT HAPPENED

Thursday's melt-up carried into Friday but on fewer names. At the 18 September close: Micron \$1,015.80, up 3.92%, back through \$1,000; AMD \$559.82, up 2.70%; the SOXX semiconductor ETF \$533.07, up 2.69%; Nvidia \$222.27, up 1.34%; and Intel \$108.60, down 0.18%, giving back a sliver of Thursday's 7.67% jump. The Nasdaq-100 proxy QQQ rose 0.63%, so the sector outran the index by roughly four to one for a second day. Separately, [Nscale's S-1](#) disclosed that Nvidia bought at least \$1bn of its \$3.1bn convertible note — a chip vendor financing a customer's data centres.

WHAT IT MEANS

Memory is where the pricing power sits right now, and Micron reclaiming four figures says the market believes the HBM and DRAM squeeze runs into next year rather than resolving. Intel going flat matters more than it looks: Thursday's 7.67% was a report about SK hynix that neither company has confirmed, and a stock that does not follow through on day two is a stock that did not get re-rated.

WATCH NEXT

Micron's fiscal Q1 on 30 September, TSMC's September revenue around 10 October, and Intel's October price rise.

TrendForce: advanced packaging stays TSMC's through 2028

WHAT HAPPENED

In a [note dated 18 September](#), TrendForce projects Nvidia high-end GPU shipments up roughly 30% year-on-year in 2026, AMD ramping MI400/MI450 from the second half, Google's TPU v7 leading custom silicon on both volume and growth, and AWS rolling out Trainium v3. The structural call is on packaging. CoWoS-S, capped at two chiplets and eight stacks of high-bandwidth memory, is giving way to CoWoS-L, already used by Nvidia, AMD and Meta's MTIA 400, with AWS and Microsoft expected to follow in 2027. Intel's EMIB-T is the credible alternative and may cost less by avoiding a large silicon interposer, with Google expected to adopt it in 2027 and AWS testing it. TrendForce still concludes CoWoS-L's "advantages in technology maturity and yield" keep it mainstream through 2028.

WHAT IT MEANS

The constraint on AI compute stopped being transistor size a while ago and became the business of gluing chips and memory together on one substrate. TSMC's packaging capacity is the actual queue everyone is standing in, which is why customers are auditioning Intel's alternative at all. Intel's foundry case leans harder on EMIB-T than on any process node — a Google design win in 2027 would be the first real proof it can take share.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Google confirms EMIB-T for a 2027 TPU.

Trump signs the Graham Act: up to 100% duties on buyers of Russian energy

WHAT HAPPENED

Trump [signed H.R. 5334](#), the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, on Friday 18 September. The [statutory text](#) says the President “shall” raise duties on goods from covered countries “to a rate of up to 100 percent ad valorem” — mandatory to act, entirely discretionary on the rate, and subject to a national-interest waiver. Covered countries are the five largest importers of Russian crude or gas over the preceding twelve months, plus the top five facilitators of sanctions evasion. The act also strikes “2026” from section 13(b) of the Iran Sanctions Act of 1996 and inserts “2031”, extending that regime five years.

WHAT IT MEANS

Do not read this as a 100% tariff. Read it as a dial the President now has to touch but can set anywhere, on a list that plainly means China, India and Turkey. A duty to act, no floor and a waiver is a structure built for leverage rather than revenue, and the value evaporates the moment a number is printed. For Indian exporters in particular, anything close to the ceiling would dwarf the tariffs already in place.

WATCH NEXT

The first designation list, and whether any rate above zero is set.

The 10-year closes back above 5%

WHAT HAPPENED

The Treasury curve sold off hard two days after the Fed’s hike to 3.75–4.00%. [Par yields on 18 September](#): 2-year 4.76% (from 4.67%), 5-year 4.86% (4.78%), 10-year 5.01% (4.94%), 30-year 5.34% (5.29%). That is 9 basis points at the front against 5 at the back — a bear flattener, meaning the short end sold off harder, which is the market pricing more tightening rather than more inflation. Crude went the other way: WTI front-month quoted near \$100.30 and Brent near \$103.87 intraday on 18 September, both roughly 1% lower on the day. Those are last quotes, not settlements.

WHAT IT MEANS

A 10-year above 5% and a chip sector up 2.7% on the same afternoon is not a contradiction that resolves quietly. One of those markets is wrong about how much the Fed still has to do, and the equity side has been wrong about that for three weeks without consequence.

WATCH NEXT

August PCE on 26 September — the first inflation print the Fed sees after hiking.

OpenAI launches a legal product, then names its own customers as competitors

WHAT HAPPENED

OpenAI [released Astra for Law on 18 September](#): GPT-6 Astra paired with a dedicated legal search index covering “US case law, statutes, and regulations across more than 230 million URLs,” sourced from the nonprofit Free Law Project. On OpenAI’s own run of Vals AI’s Legal Research Bench, it passed 54% of 200 questions against 38.7% for GPT-6 Astra with ordinary web search. Firms get zero-data-retention access through a Trusted Access programme, and 26 plugins ship with it, including Relativity and Clio. In the same announcement, OpenAI names Harvey and Legora — both of them its API customers — as companies that could build on the platform.

WHAT IT MEANS

This is platform risk arriving on schedule. Harvey raised \$550m earlier this month at a valuation that assumed the model layer stayed a supplier rather than becoming a rival; that assumption is now priced wrong. The defensible ground was never the model — it was workflow, deployment and the firm relationship — and this is the quarter they find out whether that is enough. Treat the benchmark as a vendor number: OpenAI ran it on itself.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Harvey or Legora publish an independent comparison.

Nscale files to go public on one customer and a 2028 revenue start

WHAT HAPPENED

AI data-centre builder Nscale Ltd [filed an S-1 on 18 September](#) to list on the NYSE as NSCL. Revenue for the six months to 30 June was \$140.6m against \$10.4m a year earlier — more than twelvefold — with a net loss of \$1.02bn. The filing discloses Anthropic service agreements worth “approximately \$44.6 billion” in aggregate payments, at the Monarch campus in Mason County, West Virginia; Monarch’s first 2GW gross (1.37GW of IT load) is expected online in the first half of 2028. Nscale has raised over \$4.6bn of debt since January and issued \$3.1bn of convertible notes, at least \$1bn of it bought by Nvidia. Bloomberg reports a raise of up to \$3bn; the prospectus states no amount and leaves the price range blank.

WHAT IT MEANS

A billion-dollar half-year loss going public against contracted revenue that largely starts in 2028, with one customer accounting for the headline number and that customer’s chip supplier holding the paper. Each part is normal in isolation; together they describe a company whose equity story is really a bet on Anthropic’s balance sheet two years out.

WATCH NEXT

The amended S-1 with a price range — that is when the \$3bn figure stops being a report.

Angle Health raises \$200m at \$2.7bn, and \$400m more for the cap table

WHAT HAPPENED

Angle Health, a Y Combinator Winter 2020 company selling an AI-assisted platform for small businesses buying and administering health insurance, [raised a \\$200m Series C at a \\$2.7bn valuation](#) led by Vitruvian Partners, with Town Hall Ventures, Blumberg Capital, Portage Ventures, PruVen Capital and Y Combinator. Alongside it came a \$400m tender offer for existing shareholders. The company says it serves more than 5,000 businesses and has reached profitability. It did not disclose revenue. Its product centres on level-funded health plans, the middle option between fully insured and self-funded.

WHAT IT MEANS

The tender is twice the primary raise, which tells you what this round is for: paying early employees and seed investors, not buying growth. That is a healthy sign in a company claiming profitability and a slightly awkward one in a company declining to say what it earns.

WATCH NEXT

Whether revenue gets disclosed at the next round or in an S-1.

Manus seeks \$4bn — double what Meta was blocked from paying

WHAT HAPPENED

AI agent company Manus is [in talks to raise \\$500m at a \\$4bn post-money valuation](#), roughly twice the ~\$2bn mark set when early investors helped it buy back shares. Named potential investors are IDG Capital, Boyu Capital and battery maker CATL, alongside existing backers Tencent, HSG and Zhenfund. Meta agreed to buy the company for \$2bn in December 2025, when it had over \$100m of annual recurring revenue; Beijing blocked the deal in April 2026. In August users were told to export their data “to comply with regulatory requirements in specific jurisdictions”; this month Manus said it had resumed independent operations under its founding team. The round is not closed.

WHAT IT MEANS

A blocked acquisition usually kills a company — the team has one foot out, the product drifts, the buyer’s roadmap has already absorbed it. Manus appears to have come out the other side worth double, which says the agent market moved faster in nine months than Meta’s price did. It also tests whether a Singapore-headquartered, Chinese-funded AI company can raise at scale without tripping an investment screen.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the round closes, and at what number.

The \$100,000 H-1B fee is extended a year — and still cannot be collected

WHAT HAPPENED

Two presidential actions landed on 18 September. A [proclamation](#) extends the \$100,000 H-1B payment first imposed on 19 September 2025, effective 21 September 2026 at 12:01am EDT and running twelve months. It is one-time per petition rather than annual, paid by the employer before filing on behalf of someone outside the United States; renewals, extensions, changes of status and anyone already here on a valid H-1B are not covered, and DHS may waive it case by case. A separate [executive order](#) tells adjudicators to “consider petitioner employers’ recent or planned layoffs of similarly situated U.S. workers.” But a federal court in Massachusetts vacated the implementing policy on 8 June 2026 as an unauthorised tax, and the First Circuit declined to stay that on 24 July. USCIS is still barred from collecting.

WHAT IT MEANS

This extends a policy that is under injunction, which makes it a placeholder rather than a change — the clock kept running so a win on appeal does not arrive to find the authority expired. Treat the claimed effects carefully too: outsourcing-firm registrations down 92%, consular requests down nearly 97%, FY2027 lottery entries down almost 40% are all White House figures, and the only independent estimate puts the lottery drop nearer 27%.

WATCH NEXT

The First Circuit on the merits — that is the decision that settles whether any of this operates.

Trump bars CNN, MS NOW and Politico from the White House

WHAT HAPPENED

Trump announced on Truth Social on 18 September that CNN, MS NOW and Politico are banned from the White House effective immediately, calling them “Fake News” publishing “FICTION and LIES,” and indicated more outlets could follow. [Axios, which reported it](#), said the precise scope of the access removal was unclear at publication and that the White House had not responded to a request for comment. This is one outlet’s account of a social-media post; it has not been independently confirmed here, and no formal credential revocation has been documented.

WHAT IT MEANS

Previous fights over White House access ran through the press pool — who sits where, which wire gets the rotation. Naming three organisations and removing them outright is a different instrument, and the operative question is whether it survives contact with the hard-pass system, which is administered by the Secret Service on security grounds rather than editorial ones. That is what the 2018 Acosta litigation turned on.

WATCH NEXT

Whether credentials are actually pulled, and whether the Correspondents’ Association or the outlets go to court.

Justice Department will not enforce the handgun age limit

WHAT HAPPENED

The Justice Department [said on 18 September](#) it will not criminally enforce the 1968 federal bar on licensed dealers selling handguns to adults aged 18 to 20. The Office of Legal Counsel opinion was signed by Assistant Attorney General T. Elliot Gaiser. The Supreme Court has never ruled on this specific age restriction; since the Bruen decision in 2022, three federal appeals circuits have struck down comparable restrictions and three have upheld them. Kris Brown of Brady called it “yet more evidence that the Trump administration is prioritizing the gun industry’s wishlist.”

WHAT IT MEANS

Non-enforcement is not repeal, and the gap matters commercially. The statute stands, and a dealer’s federal firearms licence — administered separately by the ATF — still turns on compliance with it. A cautious dealer therefore gains nothing, and an aggressive one is betting this administration’s discretion outlives this administration.

WATCH NEXT

A split this even usually ends at the Supreme Court; the question is who now has standing to take it there.

Germany votes Sunday with Merz on the ropes

WHAT HAPPENED

Berlin and Mecklenburg-Vorpommern hold state elections on Sunday 20 September. [Final published polling](#) has the AfD at 37% and the SPD at 35% in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, with the CDU fighting to clear the 5% threshold for seats at all; in Berlin, the AfD is at 18%, the Left Party level with the CDU, the SPD at 11%. Nationally the AfD leads the CDU by roughly 10 to 12 points. Friedrich Merz's approval is 14%, 78% of Germans reject him as chancellor, and among CDU voters 36% want him to stay against 58% who do not. He [cancelled his UN General Assembly appearance](#) to stay in Berlin.

WHAT IT MEANS

A governing party of the Federal Republic missing the 5% threshold in a state parliament would be new, and it is now a live possibility rather than a columnist's hypothetical. Merz's problem is that the obvious alternative is worse for everyone who might replace him — as the political scientist Klaus Schubert put it, “nobody wants his job.” That is what has kept him in place, and it is not a strategy.

WATCH NEXT

Results Sunday night. The CDU executive meets immediately afterwards.

Russia votes in occupied Ukraine, and keeps the observers out

WHAT HAPPENED

Russia’s three-day State Duma election for 450 seats ran Friday to Sunday. The Central Election Commission reported turnout above 20% on day one, with online voting a hundred times the 2021 level; the Donetsk People’s Republic claimed 75% early turnout, “more than a million people.” [Meduza documented](#) nearly 1,300 Communist and Yabloko observers kept out of polling stations, public-sector workers told to vote online or lose their jobs, and observers offered bribes to stop monitoring. This is the [first Duma vote in the four annexed Ukrainian regions](#) — over 3.5 million registered voters — where polling opened in late August. The European Commission called it “another blatant violation of international law.” At the front, ISW assessed that neither side advanced on 18 September.

WHAT IT MEANS

The seat count is not the point and never was. Holding a federal election in territory Russia does not fully control, with observers excluded and turnout produced by employers, converts occupation into administrative fact. The static front is the more consequential detail: neither army moved at all on Friday.

WATCH NEXT

Results 20–21 September, and whether any Western government treats the occupied-region seats as a distinct issue from the vote as a whole.

Trump says the US has permanent security control of Greenland

WHAT HAPPENED

Trump announced on 18 September that the United States has secured “permanent control over security” in Greenland at “NO COST to the United States,” including a large military presence and a veto over other countries’ military bases or sensitive investments there. [Axios reports](#) the agreement stops short of annexation and is designed to survive Greenlandic independence, with signature planned at the UN General Assembly. Copenhagen and Nuuk both confirmed an agreement but described it differently: Danish prime minister Mette Frederiksen’s office framed it as beneficial for NATO and Europe, and Greenland’s premier Jens-Frederik Nielsen said “the agreement recognizes Greenland’s interests and our place in the international cooperation.” This rests on a single outlet; the terms are not independently confirmed here.

WHAT IT MEANS

Three governments are describing one document in three ways, which usually means the text is either vague or unfinished. The substantive piece — if it holds — is the investment veto, which is aimed squarely at Chinese mining interests in Greenland and does more actual work than the basing language. “At no cost” is the claim worth reserving judgement on: security guarantees are rarely free, they are just paid somewhere the announcement does not mention.

WATCH NEXT

The signed text at UNGA next week, and whether the Danish parliament gets a vote on it.

SOURCES

[Office of the Governor of California — executive order on AI oversight](#)

[Anthropic — embedded evaluation with Accenture](#)

[Accenture Newsroom — embedded evaluators at Anthropic](#)

[The Decoder — 42 Royal Society Fellows on AI existential risk](#)

[SiliconANGLE — Hacktron’s “HEIF Heist” disclosure](#)

[The Decoder — OpenAI launches Astra for Law](#)

[TrendForce — CoWoS-L, EMIB-T and AI packaging to 2028](#)

[The White House — H.R. 5334 signed into law](#)

[GovInfo — text of H.R. 5334, Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026](#)

[US Treasury — daily yield curve, September 2026](#)

[SEC EDGAR — Nscale Ltd Form S-1](#)

[TechCrunch — Angle Health’s \\$200m Series C](#)

[TechCrunch — Manus seeks \\$4bn valuation](#)

[The White House — proclamation on H-1B entry restrictions](#)

[The White House — H-1B fact sheet](#)

[Axios](#) — Trump bars CNN, MS NOW and Politico

[Axios](#) — DOJ will not enforce handgun age limit

[Irish Times](#) — Merz and Sunday's German state elections

[EUobserver](#) — German polling before the state elections

[Meduza](#) — Duma elections open

[NPR](#) — Russia holds a parliamentary vote in seized Ukrainian regions

[Kyiv Independent](#) — Russian strikes over the past day

[Axios](#) — Trump on a Greenland security agreement

[Trading Economics](#) — crude oil